

## ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

### PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared on a website:

#### Comfort food

For many people, the idea of 'comfort food' means food on the heavy side: big on carbs, fatty or rich, like a bucket of deep-fried chicken or a warm bowl of instant noodles. The notion of 'guilty pleasures' is never far away. However, comfort food can also be food that brings us back to our childhood, like mother's chicken soup or home-made congee.

Studies suggest that when we associate foods with the security of childhood, it gives us warm and happy feelings. This also explains why, when we feel stressed, we often turn to comfort food to make ourselves feel better, even if the feeling is only temporary.

What counts as comfort food is different from person to person. In one study of American preferences, males preferred warm, hearty, meal-related comfort foods such as steak and potatoes because these foods reminded them of being 'cared for' or spoiled. In contrast, females preferred comfort foods that are snack-related such as chocolate and ice cream because these foods were associated with low amounts of work and less 'clean up'.

In a recent survey conducted in Hong Kong during the pandemic, the top three favourite snacks of locals were potato chips, biscuits and ice cream.

Humans have a fundamental need to belong and comfort food is a way for people to obtain a sense of belonging even when the people they are close to are not close by.

Your group is doing a project on comfort food. You are meeting to discuss this topic. You may want to talk about:

- reasons why people eat comfort food
- whether comfort food can be part of a healthy diet
- other ways to reduce stress and improve mental health
- anything else you think is important

### PART B Individual Response

1. What is your favourite comfort food?
2. When do you eat comfort food?
3. Should snacks be banned from school?
4. Do young and old people like the same kind of comfort food?
5. Did your eating habits change during the pandemic?
6. Should companies provide comfort food for their employees?
7. Should comfort food come with health warnings?
8. Do you think you could live without comfort food?